Session 6.1

Creating Posters and Flyers

You use posters and flyers to communicate messages containing relatively small amounts of information that you want people to remember and to act upon. Both posters and flyers provide you with an inexpensive way to distribute these messages. The words you choose to include on a poster and on a flyer are extremely important. Few words are required and every word must count.

A **poster** announces a specific message and is often similar in style and content to a print advertisement. A poster includes minimal text with maximum punch and usually includes pictures or other graphics to catch the attention of passersby. Good venues for posters are those where people congregate or stand in line. With nothing much to do except wait, people naturally read whatever print matter is visible.

A **flyer** differs from a poster in that it usually contains more text and is designed to be read like a normal document rather than as an item posted on a wall. Flyers consist of one page that is printed on one side or both sides. Most flyers are simple 8½ × 11-inch sheets of paper that can be folded or left flat. For many small companies, the flyer format provides an excellent advertising medium because flyers can be produced relatively inexpensively, particularly if they are printed in black and white and do not include many graphics.

In this session, you will explore ways in which you can use posters and flyers to promote a business or an organization, and then you will investigate how to develop and format appropriate content and how small companies and organizations can create their own posters and flyers on limited budgets.

Identifying Applications for Posters and Flyers

You can apply the term poster to something as small as a simple, letter-size announcement of an upcoming garage sale and to something as big as a multistory banner designed to advertise a company or an event to thousands of people at a time. A poster for a Broadway show, for example, could be made into a huge billboard that covers the whole side of a building. A flyer can be a price list printed in black and white for distribution to local customers or it can be a glossy, colorful advertising piece mailed to millions of people worldwide.

Poster Uses

You can divide uses for posters into two principal categories: to announce and to publicize. You create a poster to announce a special event such as a rock concert, a grand opening sale, or a softball game. Figure 6-1 shows an example of how Wild Greens uses a poster to announce a vegetable cooking demonstration by Jurgen Egbert, the "Wild Green Chef."

Poster to announce a special event Figure 6-1



A poster that announces a special event is temporary. The company or organization hangs copies of the poster in various venues for a few weeks before the event and then removes them following the event. Posters for major events such as festivals and exhibitions can become collectors' items, although generally only if they have been professionally designed and include unique artwork.

You can also create a poster to publicize information about a specific issue such as good nutrition or homelessness. Figure 6-2 shows a poster that Wild Greens created to publicize the benefits of eating organically grown food. Wild Greens will hang this poster in their store, in local community centers, and in the offices of local physicians who are interested in promoting good nutrition.

Figure 6-2 Publicity poster

True or False:
There's a Difference Between Organic Food and "Regular" Food

True:

Organic Food Tastes Better!

It's No Myth
Organic food really does taste better *and* it's better for you.



Wild Greens
The Great Good Food Place, 210 Quay Street, Auckland, NZ
www.wildgreensauckland.nz
(09) 555 0758

The purpose of both the special event and publicity posters is to generate awareness. As a result, both kinds of posters need to attract attention and then to compel people to act. An event poster should intrigue people about the event and provide them with the information they need to attend the event. A publicity poster should emphasize a specific message such as "Stop Smoking" or "Eat Healthy," and should include contact information so that people can obtain more information.

Flyer Uses

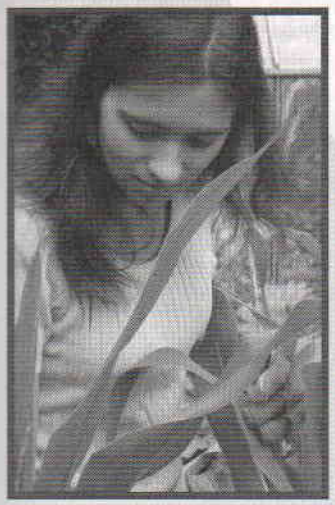
You can make a flyer to share information about a wide range of topics. For example, you can create a flyer to advertise sale items, to provide customers with information about a product or service, to share a schedule of courses, or to distribute a price list. The uses for the one-page flyer are almost endless. Figure 6-3 shows a flyer that tells customers the story of Wild Greens.

Company information flyer Figure 6-3

The Story of Wild Greens

One sunny Sunday not so many years ago, Grace Holtz decided to take a drive into the country. She was fresh out of university and working as a computer programmer in Wellington. She was good at her job, but something was missing. She found it that sunny Sunday in the form of a 10-hectare hobby farm with a For Sale sign. Grace bought the farm and within a year had converted most of her hectares into vegetable plots.

Grace grew everything organically and soon found herself with a surplus of great-tasting produce. She built a small roadside stand to sell her organically grown fruits and vegetables and within weeks was attracting people from all over the greater Wellington area. But one customer in particular was to change Grace's direction forever.



At just 24, Grace Holtz is one of the youngest and most successful entrants into the competitive retail food market.

Enter Sean McNair, an entrepreneur from Auckland. Mr. McNair stopped by Grace's roadside stand and bought a kilo of tomatoes and a kilo of apples. From the first bite of his apple, Sean was hooked. He found in Grace a dynamo waiting for an opportunity to take on the world. Together Grace and Sean formed a partnership and *Wild Greens* was born.

With Sean's help, Grace found the perfect location on Prince's Wharf overlooking Auckland Harbour. She put her heart, her soul, and her produce into *Wild Greens* and by 2006, Grace had won a place for herself in the gastronomic hearts of Aucklanders who also share Grace's passionate dedication to keeping our environment clean and beautiful.

Wild Greens has earned its reputation for providing its customers with both a positive shopping experience and superior food products that taste good, look good, and are packed full of great nutrition.

Wild Greens
***The Great Good Food Place*, 210 Quay Street, Auckland, NZ**
www.wildgreensauckland.nz
Phone: (09) 555 0758 Fax: (09) 555 0760

The flyer shown in Figure 6-3 provides readers with a straightforward account of how owner Grace Holtz developed Wild Greens from a roadside fruit-and-vegetable stand to the current store and café. However, the flyer was not produced just to share an interesting story. The real purpose of the flyer is to show customers how Wild Greens differs from a large-chain supermarket. The flyer content is skillfully written to appeal to a customer's desire for a more human-scale shopping experience in which personal service, healthy food, and social responsibility are key components.

Two distinguishing characteristics of a flyer are as follows:

- You design a flyer to communicate information to groups of individuals rather than to just one individual. As a result, a flyer differs from a document such as a memo or a report that is usually designed to be read by just a few individuals. The content of a flyer must be much more general than the content of a document such as a report or a memo because it will be read by many hundreds, even thousands of people.
- You limit the length of a flyer to one page that includes text on one or both sides. You can sometimes include more text in a flyer than in a poster because a flyer is designed to be picked up and read, rather than seen from a distance. You can also create a flyer that resembles a miniposter. The difference between the flyer and the poster version in this instance is one of distribution and size. The poster will generally be tacked to a wall and be formatted on a larger piece of paper and with larger text than a flyer. A flyer can be in the form of a simple 8½ × 11-inch page or it can be reduced to a half page, or even a postcard size.

Because the uses for flyers are so diverse, the designs for flyers are also extremely wide ranging. You can include text in tables and text boxes, add graphic elements such as shapes, pictures, and lines, and apply shading to various elements on the page. You will examine design issues later in this session.

Developing Poster and Flyer Content

If you are asked to develop a poster or a flyer, you are likely to think first about what the document should look like. Because both document types are very visual, the focus naturally is on layout, graphics, and other design elements. However, you first need to identify the *reason* why you need to create the document because you want to make sure that your content will communicate what you intend. You can identify the reason by asking a question. Here are some sample questions:

- Do you want to encourage people to come to a specific event?
- Do you need people to change their opinions about an issue?
- Do you want people to be better informed about the products you sell?

The answers to each of these questions will help you to develop appropriate content for a specific type of poster or flyer. For example, if you answer "yes" to the first question, you need to develop content that attracts attention and provides people with the information they need to attend the event. If you answer "yes" to the second question, you need content that will elicit a thoughtful response to your message. Finally, if you answer "yes" to the third question, you need informative, appealing content about your products. You'll look next at how to develop appropriate content for a poster and then for a flyer.

Developing Poster Content

As you learned earlier, a poster usually advertises a specific event or draws the attention of onlookers to a specific issue. You use different approaches to develop content for these two poster types. For a poster that advertises an event, you should include the following information:

- Identification of the event, including the name of the event and a short description
- Date, time, and location of the event
- Where to get further information: phone number, e-mail address, and Web site
- Ticket price, if appropriate
- A reason why onlookers should consider attending the event

The reason why the reader should attend the event should imply some kind of benefit. For example, a poster advertising a concert could include a line such as "One of Europe's top violinists." In the poster shown in Figure 6-1 that advertises the cooking class by the "Wild Green Chef," the line "Mom never cooked like this" is included to imply that students will learn cooking techniques they might never have encountered before.

To simplify the process of gathering content for a poster that advertises an event, you can complete a table similar to the table shown in Figure 6-4. At this stage in the content development process, you do not want to worry about coming up with snappy wording or selecting interesting graphics. You are concerned only with assembling all the information that must be included—in some shape or form—on the finished poster.

Figure 6-4 shows how Grace gathered and organized information for a Wild Greens poster that will advertise a book-signing event for a local cookbook author.

Developing content for an event poster Figure 6-4

Content Type	Description
Identification of the event	Cookbook signing by local cookbook author Donna Deville. Donna will be signing her new cookbook *On Your Own*, which features recipes for young people who have moved away from home and need to learn how to cook delicious dinners on a limited budget.
Date	Saturday, October 11, 2008
Time	Noon to 4 p.m.
Location	Wild Greens at 210 Quay Street in Auckland
Further information	Call 555-0758 or check *www.wildgreensauckland.nz*
Ticket price	None; the book *On Your Own* will be on sale for a special price of $14.99 (regular price is $25.00).
Benefit	People who come to the event can meet and get cooking tips from Donna Deville, the author of 10 popular cookbooks and a long-time resident of Auckland.

When you create a poster that must draw attention to a specific issue, you require the following information:

- Identification of the issue ("Eat Healthy" or "Improve Literacy")
- Indication of how the reader should respond; for example, by contacting an organization, making a donation, and so forth
- Name of the sponsoring organization
- Benefit to the reader of responding to the poster; for example, help others, improve your life, get healthy, and so on

The process of gathering information for a poster helps you to focus attention on the purpose of the poster and what content you should include to achieve this purpose. You do not necessarily need to include all of the content you gather in the finished poster. However, by gathering as much information as possible, you make sure that you do not omit important information.

Developing Flyer Content

Whereas posters are usually used to advertise events or to raise awareness about issues, almost any topic of interest to a group of people could be the subject of a flyer. Therefore, when you develop content for a flyer, you must first focus on why you are creating a flyer in the first place. Following are some questions to ask:

- What objective do I want to achieve as a result of distributing a flyer?
- What topics will help me achieve that objective?
- How would the reader benefit from reading the topics contained in the flyer?
- What details are required for the flyer?
- What contact information is needed for the flyer?
- How should I distribute the flyers?

Figure 6-5 shows how Grace gathered and organized information for a flyer that Wild Greens plans to distribute at the book-signing event described in Figure 6-4. This flyer will be printed on a half sheet and included inside every copy of the *On Your Own* cookbook sold from Wild Greens on the day of the book-signing event.

Figure 6-5 **Developing content for a flyer**

Content Type	Description
Flyer objective	To inform readers that they can buy Earth-friendly cookbooks from Wild Greens and then to describe three of the top sellers.
Flyer topics	Description of three cookbooks: *The Valiant Vegetable*, Sherry Watson, Pacifica Press, 2008. *Fruits of Our Labours*, Douglas Kernoe, Southern Cross Publications, 2008. *Polynesian Feast*, Kiri Lanaka, South Seas Press, 2008.
Reader benefits	Expand their repertoire of great-tasting recipes made from organic produce.
Details	Available for purchase at Wild Greens. Prices are not provided in the flyer so that the flyer remains current even if the books go on sale.
Contact information	Wild Greens at 210 Quay Street in Auckland Call (09) 555-0758 or check *www.wildgreensauckland.nz*

Grace also needs to develop a poster and a flyer to publicize an international food-tasting event at the Wild Greens Café adjacent to the Wild Greens food market. She asks you to gather the information required for a poster to advertise the event and a flyer to provide information about the food featured at the event and to highlight the qualification of the chef.



To gather content for a poster and flyer:

1. Open the file **Event** from the Tutorial.06\Tutorial folder included with your Data Files.
2. To avoid altering the original file, save the document as **Poster and Flyer Content** in the same folder.

3. Read the directions at the beginning of the document. You need to complete the tables provided with information about a poster and a flyer to publicize the international food-tasting event at the Wild Greens Café.
4. Write your own entries in the appropriate areas of the table. You can make any assumptions you want about the company and the café. You can also select an appropriate date and time for the event.
5. Type your name where indicated at the bottom of the document, save the document, and then print a copy.

After you have determined why you need a poster and flyer and you have identified appropriate content, you need to identify how and where you plan to distribute them. A stack of beautifully formatted flyers that sits on a shelf because a distribution method was not identified is a waste of company resources. You need to make a list of venues in your local community that have space to show the poster or to keep a stack of flyers on hand. If resources are available, you can distribute flyers through the post office or as inserts in catalogs and newspapers.

Developing a Compelling Design

Both posters and flyers are intended to attract attention so that people will stop and read the text. The requirements for posters and flyers vary somewhat because of how they are distributed. A poster needs to grab the attention of people who are engaged in other activities and not thinking at all about the content of a poster. Large font sizes are used to format the most important text, and in most posters, pictures play a crucial role.

A flyer, on the other hand, needs to appear compelling enough to be picked up by an interested reader. However, after the flyer is in the reader's hands, the information can be communicated using normal-sized text and more subtle graphics.

Although different in terms of how they are read, you can design your posters and flyers in accordance with the CLEAR design guidelines:

- **C**omposition
- **L**ayout
- **E**nergy
- **A**ttention
- **R**epetition

You can use these guidelines to help you identify areas of your documents that might need editing. For example, if you are aware of the effect that repetition can have on readers, you can take care to include some repeated text or objects. Each of the CLEAR design guidelines are discussed next.

Developing the Composition

Composition refers to the words you select to communicate the content you have identified for your poster or flyer. Some of these words do not require a great deal of thought. For example, you can easily write the text to describe the date, time, and location of an event. The text that requires thought is the text that needs to attract and hold the attention of readers. For a poster, you need to create a snappy headline that encourages a reader to stop, look, and understand. For a flyer, you need to include an interesting title that compels the reader's eye down to the text.

Developing a snappy headline takes time and patience. Most writers, even professional writers, are not able to come up with the perfect headline for a poster in just a few minutes. Usually, a great deal of trial and error is required. A good practice is to jot down as many headlines as you can think of, even headlines that you know are too weak or too long. Figure 6-6 shows some headlines for the poster that Wild Greens needs to create to advertise the book-signing event.

Figure 6-6 **Sample headlines for a poster**

- Wild Greens Book Signing
- Give the Gift of Cooking to Someone You Love!
- Meet Donna Deville—the Kiwi Chef Extraordinaire
- What's Cooking at Wild Greens?
- Wild Green Writer

Of the headlines shown here, "Wild Green Writer" is chosen because it ties in with a marketing focus that Wild Greens is developing. The company has already used "Wild Green Chef" to advertise its cooking demonstrations, so it decides to extend the image to the book-signing event.

For a flyer, you can include a headline followed by conventional text that expands on the flyer topics. Most people read a flyer once and then discard it. As a result, the text included in a flyer should be easy to read and simple to understand. Figure 6-7 shows text for a flyer that describes the three cookbooks Wild Greens plans to feature at the book-signing event.

Sample flyer text Figure 6-7

What's Cooking at Wild Greens?

You already know that you can buy the very freshest organic produce at Wild Greens, but did you know that you can also choose from our extensive collection of earth-friendly cookbooks? Here are three of our newest additions to help you extend your cooking power!

The Valiant Vegetable

Lovers of fine cookbooks with a vegetarian focus will already be familiar with Sherry Watson's down-home, easy-to-cook recipes. Few people can make a green bean sing an aria to great taste, but Sherry Watson can—and she can teach you how too! In *The Valiant Vegetable*, Sherry brings together an eclectic collection of recipes that feature vegetables in all their glorious colors and varieties. How about Lemon Thyme Roasted Tomatoes or Braised Beets with Fennel? This full-colour cookbook includes over 150 recipes for appetizers, soups, main courses, and even desserts. Yes, Sherry Watson teaches you how to make desserts from vegetables—and we're not just talking another carrot cake!

The Valiant Vegetable, Sherry Watson, Pacifica Press, 2008.

Fruits of Our Labours

Chef Douglas Kernoe loves fruit—all kinds of fruit. And fortunately for cooking enthusiasts, "Chef D" shares his secrets in this glossy, full-colour cookbook that covers fruits from Apricots to Xiguas (that's a type of melon!). Learn how to make Lime-Rhubarb Soufflé, Raspberry Mélange, and Blueberry-Kiwi Muffins. This 200-page cookbook also includes tips on growing your own fruit, how to make great fruit preserves, and a fruit selection shopping guide.

Fruits of Our Labours, Douglas Kernoe, Southern Cross Publications, 2008.

Polynesian Feast

Kiri Lanaka's classic book was first published in 1980 and since then has gone through six editions. The sixth edition takes Polynesian cuisine to new heights with recipes such as Coconut-Mango-Macadamia Nut Pie, Shrimp-Pineapple Crepes, and Fijian Sweet Potatoes with Bananas. Chef Lanaka also regales us with stories of her Maori heritage and includes recipes from the islands and cultures all over the South Pacific. If you have never tried cooking Polynesian, then this book is for you, and if you're already an old hand, you'll find dozens of new recipes that will give your taste buds a whole new definition of "wake-up call."

Polynesian Feast, Kiri Lanaka, South Seas Press, 2008.

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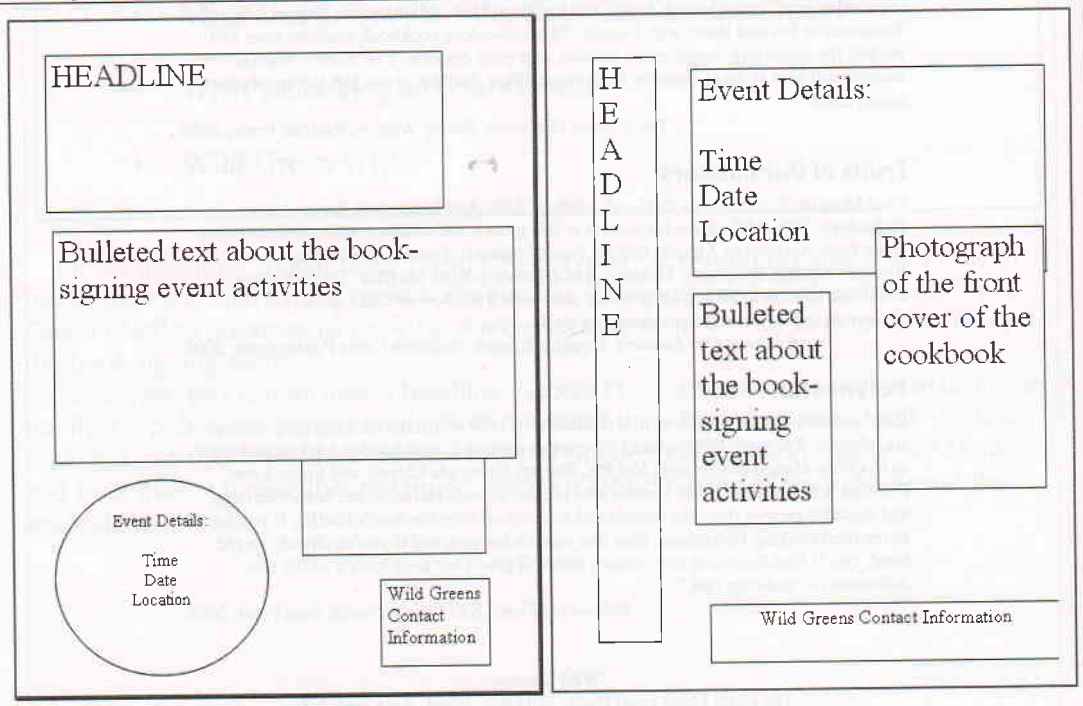
Notice that the headline for the sample flyer is "What's Cooking at Wild Greens?". This headline was included in Figure 6-6 as one of the headlines that was generated for the event poster. The headline was too long for a poster, but works well as the headline for the flyer about three cookbooks available for sale at Wild Greens. An efficient writer recycles text wherever possible.

Selecting a Layout

After you have composed text for a poster or flyer, you choose how you want the text and graphics to appear on the page. The term **layout** refers to how you arrange the various components of the document with relation to each other on the page, including text blocks, graphics, and headings. The most effective layouts are often the cleanest and simplest. A poster or flyer that is cluttered with too much text and too many images confuses readers. If you are creating a poster, you need to be aware that people must be able to read the poster from a distance.

To develop an effective layout, first identify the components required for the document, and then make some preliminary sketches. You can even draw shapes in Microsoft Word to identify where you want blocks of text and graphics to appear. Figure 6-8 shows two ways in which the content for the book-signing event flyer could be laid out.

Figure 6-8 Sample layout options for book-signing poster

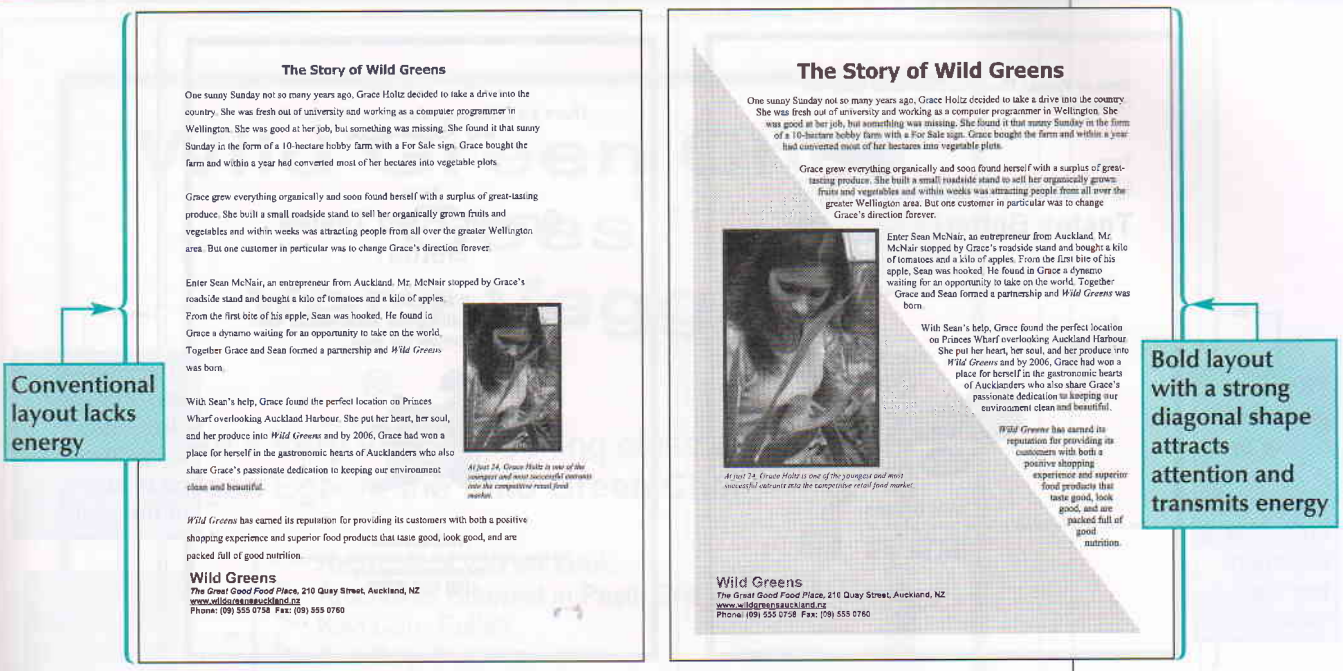


You need to experiment with different positions for the various components until you are satisfied with the layout. You can add the actual text and graphics later.

Transmitting Energy

A document transmits **energy** when the content literally leaps off the page and into the reader's consciousness. You can best understand the concept of energy when you compare two versions of a poster. In Figure 6-9, the poster at the left is "ho hum." All the required content is in place, but few readers would give it a second look.

Creating energy in a flyer Figure 6-9



The poster to the right in Figure 6-9 contains the same information as the poster to the left. However, the use of an interesting graphic and a strong diagonal line gives the content energy. The effect is bold and exciting.

When you are creating a poster or a flyer, think about the concept of energy. Visualize the reader looking at your document. Does the content inspire the reader to look twice? Think about how you can arrange the various components of the document to create some tension and thereby transmit energy.

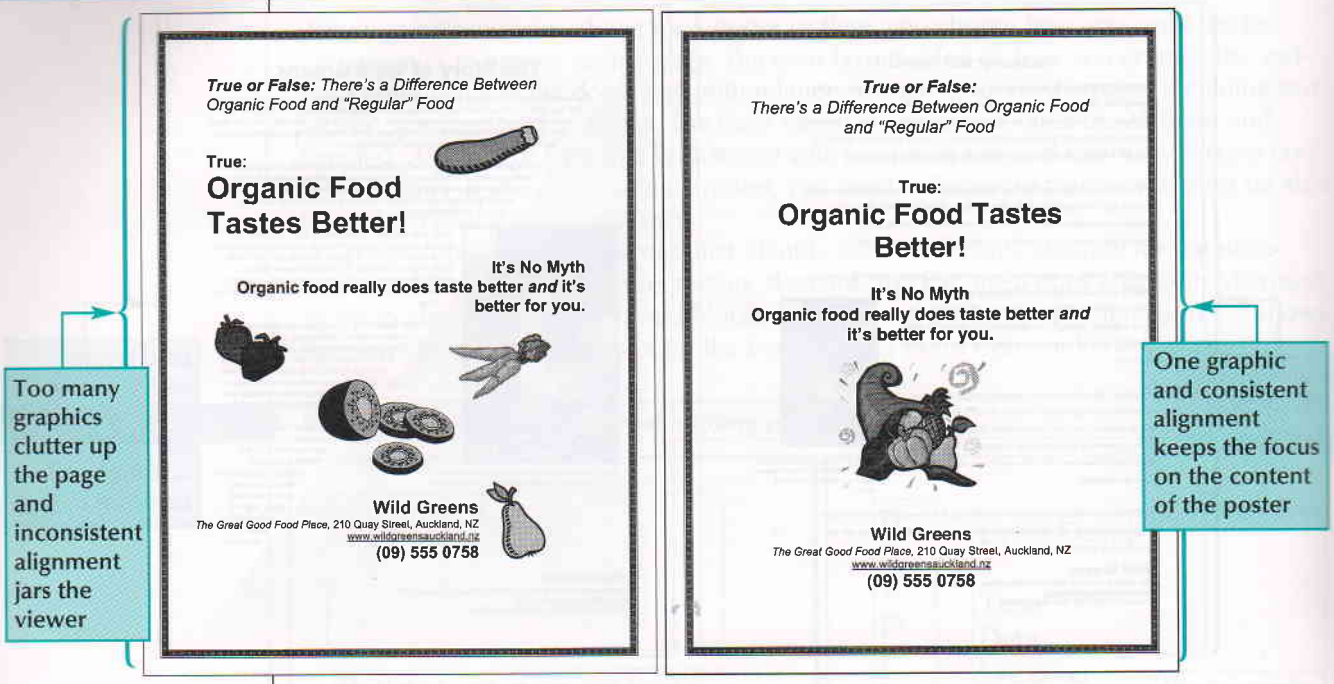
You also need to be careful not to overdo your attempts to add excitement to your documents. Sometimes a more conservative approach is preferable, depending on the needs and expectations of the people who will read the document. As with all business documents, reader needs are of paramount importance.

Gaining Attention

You gain **attention** through the use of fonts, font sizes, and graphics. You usually format a headline with a larger font size and less important details with smaller font sizes. You should limit the number of font sizes to three or four at the most and apply the same font size to similar text. For example, you would use the same font size to format the date, time, and location details about an event.

You can also use pictures and other graphics to attract attention. Again, you need to use graphics sparingly to gain maximum effect. Compare the two posters shown in Figure 6-10. The excessive number of graphics in the poster to the left gives the poster an amateur look. Most viewers know enough about word processing to understand that the person who created the poster spent most of the design time surfing for cool Clip Art rather than focusing on how best to communicate a message. The text in the poster is also aligned inconsistently. The viewer scans the poster with no clear idea of how to identify the most important information. The viewer does not know where to look first.

Figure 6-10 Choosing a balanced layout



The poster to the right includes just one graphic and relies on the use of a large font size to attract attention to the most important text: "Organic Food Tastes Better!" In addition, all the text elements are center-aligned and consistently spaced.

If you are a skilled designer, you can achieve striking effects through the use of different alignment patterns. However, your first priority should be to maintain consistency and simplicity. If you are not sure how best to display text in a poster, use the conventional center-alignment format.

Using Repetition

The subtle use of **repetition** in a poster or flyer can be very effective, so long as it is not overdone. For example, you can format the company name in the same way each time it appears to make it stand out from the rest of the text, or you can repeat a graphic object two or three times. As with all design guidelines, the use of repetition must contribute to the overall impact of the document. Figure 6-11 shows two ways in which repetition is used in the design of a poster.

Examples of repetition in a poster Figure 6-11



As you create a poster or a flyer, analyze your efforts with relation to the five "CLEAR" guidelines and then experiment with a variety of different looks. Designing a promotional document such as a poster or flyer requires time and thought. Try not to rush the process.